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AFP

■ Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) chairman and election candidate Tarique Rahman (centre) casts his ballot at a polling station during Bangladesh's general election in Dhaka.

Counting under way in first Bangladesh polls since uprising

Leading prime ministerial hopeful Tarique Rahman says he is confident of win

DHAKA

Counting was underway yesterday in Bangladesh's first election since a deadly 2024 uprising, with powerful political heir Tarique Rahman bullish about defeating an Islamist-led coalition.

Leading prime ministerial hopeful Tarique Rahman, 60, said he was "confident" his Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) — which was crushed during the 15 years of ousted premier Sheikh Hasina's autocratic rule — can regain power in the South Asian nation of 170 million people.

However, he faces a stiff challenge from a coalition led by the Muslim-majority country's largest Islamist party, Jamaat-e-Islami.

Election Commission officials reported "a few minor disruptions" but top party leaders on both sides raised fears of threats, with the BNP's Rahman calling on people to vote so that "conspiracies will not succeed".

Grassroots campaign

Jamaat chief Shafiqur Rahman, 67, mounted a disciplined grassroots campaign, hoping to form the first Islamist-led government in constitutionally secular Bangladesh.

Jamaat, which has campaigned on a platform of justice and ending corruption, senses its biggest opportunity in decades, with party leader Rahman saying it "will do whatever is required" to ensure a fair result. "The early results indicate something positive", the Jamaat chief said, as counting continued.

BNP's Rahman has said he is "confident" of victory, and his advisor said the party would "secure a sweeping victory".

Many opinion polls give the BNP the lead, although some suggest a knife-edge race.

Significant first results are expected to be released overnight. Heavy deployments of security forces are posted countrywide, with UN experts warning ahead of voting of "growing intolerance, threats and attacks" and a "tsunami of disinformation".

Political clashes killed five people and injured more than 600 during campaigning, police records show.

Like millions of young voters, Shithi Goswami, 21, a student at Dhaka City College, cast her ballot for the first time.

"I hope after everything we went through the last few years, now is the time for something positive," she said.

Interim leader Muhammad Yunus, who will step down once the new government takes power, has said the vote would "determine the future direction of the country".

— AFP
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Trump sticks to Iran talks amid new US build-up

TEHRAN EXPANDS PROTECTIVE MEASURES AT NUCLEAR FACILITIES

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump has insisted that negotiations with Iran must continue, even as Washington accelerates military preparations and fresh satellite imagery reveals new activity at Tehran's nuclear facilities.

Following a closed-door meeting with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu at the White House, Trump said diplomacy remained his preferred course. "There was nothing definitive reached other than I insisted that negotiations with Iran continue to see whether or not a deal can be consummated," Trump said, signalling resistance to Israeli calls for a tougher stance.

The remarks come amid reports of an expanding American military posture in the region.

Military moves

US defence officials have indicated that the Pentagon has instructed a second aircraft carrier strike group to prepare for possible deployment to the Middle East. The USS George H.W. Bush Carrier Strike Group could depart within weeks if required, according to US media reports. The military signalling coincides with developments inside Iran.

Fresh satellite imagery analysed by independent observers shows tunnel entrances at

US defence officials have indicated that the Pentagon has instructed a second aircraft carrier strike group to prepare for possible deployment to the Middle East.

the Isfahan nuclear site buried under soil, alongside new structures observed at both Isfahan and the key Natanz facility. Analysts say the construction may reflect efforts to secure sensitive infrastructure following earlier strikes.

Recent images reviewed by nuclear monitoring groups indicate that Iran carried out building work at Natanz between December and January. BBC-cited assessments suggest the additions could be linked to recovery or protective measures at areas previously damaged. The activity unfolds as diplomatic manoeuvring intensifies around Tehran's nuclear programme, which remains a central source of friction between Iran, the US and Israel.

While Washington continues to pursue negotiations, Trump has repeatedly warned of severe consequences should talks fail.

The parallel tracks of diplomacy, military pressure and nuclear-site activity have heightened concerns that miscalculation could further destabilise an already volatile region.

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Peak accident times, most dangerous days revealed

Insurance data shows when motorists face greatest risks

DUBAI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

While Ramadan is a time of reflection and togetherness with loved ones, every year during the fasting month, hundreds of road accidents and dozens of fatalities in the UAE cast a shadow. New data revealed yesterday shows exactly when drivers face the greatest risk during the fasting month.

Working with RoadSafeUAE, Al Wathba Insurance analysed 2,771 motor insurance claims from last year's Ramadan period. The analysis showed that the hours between noon and 6pm see the highest number of accidents, accounting for 43 per cent of all claims.

The riskiest two-hour window falls between 2pm and



4pm, when 17 per cent of accidents occur.

Post-Iftar hours from 6pm to midnight see another spike, with 28 per cent of incidents.

Mondays and Thursdays

The data also reveals that Mondays and Thursdays are the most dangerous days, each accounting for 17 per cent of weekly accidents. Sundays proved safest, with just nine per cent of incidents.

Drivers aged 36-40 emerged as the highest-risk group, involved in 24 per cent of accidents. The data showed that in 65 per cent of cases, a third party was at fault, while own-fault accidents accounted for just 35 per cent of claims, underscoring the importance of staying alert to other drivers' actions.

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